



OB for Social Development: A Position Paper

Pradip N. Khandwalla

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PRADIP N. KHANDWALLA (INDIA)

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OB and the Third World

Organizational behavior (OB) is an area of knowledge rather than a unified theory. It consists of a growing clutch of concepts, approaches, models, and tools pertinent to the structure and functioning of organizations within their socioeconomic contexts and of the study of individuals and groups within their organizational contexts [1]. Thus, OB spans para-organizational concerns such as interorganizational networks and delivery systems. It deals with macro-organizational phenomena—organizational goals, strategies, climates, cultures, structure, management styles, and performances—and how they are shaped by one another and by such contextual factors as operating environments, societal values and institutions, technology, size, dependence, and other

Dr. Khandwalla is Larsen and Toubro Professor of Organizational Behaviour, Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad 380 015, India.

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factors. OB also looks at organizationwide processes such as decision making, socialization, and institution building. It is equally concerned with the motivations, attitudes, skills, and interactional dynamics of individuals and groups operating within organizations and the two-way influences between macro-organizational variables and these micro-organizational concerns.

OB is highly differentiated, rife with contending theoretical perspectives, multiple levels of analysis, and diverse research philosophies and methods [2–4]. It has generated a rich variety of management tools and technologies. These range from organization development (OD) types of intervention to various kinds of training, management by objectives (MBO), human resource management systems, modes of decision making, ways of making the job more interesting, organizational design gestalts, etc. Some of these tools and techniques that have been used successfully in the Third World are listed in Table 1.

Table 1

Illustrative OB Tools for Use in Strategic Organizations

Diagnostic tools: Action research, survey feedback, search conference

Individual level tools: Leadership and supervisory training, achievement motivation training, creativity training, stress-management training, entrepreneurship training, change agency training, job enrichment and task design

Group effectiveness tools: Participative decision-making, team building, process consultation, confrontation meetings, conscientization

Structure-related tools: Role clarification, decentralization, differentiation and integration, design of organizational chart

System tools: Management by objectives system, human resource development system

The organizations of poor societies seeking development tend to be replete with “people” problems. The combination of scarcity-ridden economies, the high development aspirations of social elites, and the traditionalism and kinship orientation of the “masses” is a fascinating context. It often spawns bizarre organizational behavior. Under a proactive social leadership, scarcity breeds institutionalized means for alleviating it. Thus, a broad range of governmental, quasi-governmental, voluntary, and private commercial organizations with scarcity-alleviation goals comes into existence. But these organizations are commonly staffed by members of the traditional, kinship-oriented, impoverished masses; and often the clients of these organizations are also segments of the masses. Add to that public funding of many of these organizations, and what emerges is a queer cocktail of organizations with entrepreneurial, developmental aspirations at the top, bureaucratic structures, nepotistic staff cultures, fairly modern operations technologies, and installation of some professional management tools and systems. The organizations of developing societies, especially the larger, strategic ones, tend to be melting pots of people struggling to understand the modalities of internal coherence and external relevance. They are the laboratories for the growth experiments of some 3 billion human beings.

Most of the tools and techniques of OB have originated in the West, but they have become important elements of management software in some of the larger organizations of the Third World [5]. In India, for instance, such tools as survey feedback [6], action research [7], organization development [8], management by objectives [9], human resource development systems [10], stress management techniques,¹ achievement activation training [11], creative problem-solving training [12], and others have been used in a number of organizations. Although selective use of these tools and techniques in appropriate organizational situations is unquestioned, there are doubts about their wholesale applicability in Third World countries because of their

apparent conflicts with the cultural, economic, and political realities of those countries [5,13].

The main normative focus in OB is effectiveness. At the organizational level, criteria used in Western research have, by and large, emphasized organizational performance variables, e.g., profitability and growth rate; system effectiveness variables, e.g., adaptability and success in acquiring resources; staff well-being; and, occasionally, corporate social responsibility-related criteria [14–17]. A criterion of special relevance for the developing world is the effective contribution of the organization to socioeconomic development [18–20]. Developing countries commonly suffer from scarce managerial skills, low work ethic, a weak cooperation ethic, high dependency proneness, and conservatism [21–24].

Organized action—as distinct from sporadic individual or group action—offers vast possibilities for expediting socioeconomic development. This is because the formal organization brings under one roof all the human, material, financial, and technological resources needed to undertake relatively unfamiliar, long-range, nation-building tasks. Also, formal organizations have the intrinsic ability to amass rapidly whatever additional resources they need. Indeed, most developing societies have set up a variety of special-purpose organizations whose main objective is contributing to various facets of socioeconomic development.

In India, for example, soon after Independence the government set up a planning commission at the national level plus organizations to promote community development in the rural sector, provide project financing to new industries, and produce goods and services basic to rapid industrialization (e.g., steel mills, equipment-producing plants, basic chemicals-producing units, etc.). In addition, attempts were made to reorient governmental administrative organizations from merely providing routine services such as revenue collection and maintenance of law

and order toward also contributing to socioeconomic development by drawing up developmental plans [22,25,26].

Conceptualization of the strategic organization, group, and individual

A large amount of research on OB has dealt with different kinds of organization and different facets of organizations and their functioning [27,28].² But work on the strategic organization as a separate category has been negligible. If, within each class of organization, we were to array organizations according to their potential contribution to positive change and development within their respective domains or sectors, then strategic organizations would be the top scorers in each array. Thus, organizations that are research and development oriented, organizations that pioneer in a sector needing products, services, and technologies, organizations attempting to change social values and attitudes—in short, organizations whose outputs and actions have a long-term, developmental impact in their domains—may be considered strategic organizations [19].

The potential of organizations for contributing to socioeconomic development of poor, underdeveloped societies may vary enormously. To survive, organizations must meet some social need or another [29]. But only a few organizations may be primarily concerned with meeting society's (or a segment of society's) need to transform itself in the direction of some ideal. Although societies surely differ in terms of cherished utopias, the majority appear to equate socioeconomic development with greater strength and autonomy for the society as a whole and for individuals and groups in that society, greater social justice and equity, and greater per capita availability of at least essential goods and services [30–32].

Interorganizational comparisons based on the “fuzzy” criteria of social development are difficult. However, it is possible to say

that an administrative organization set up to promote literacy, family planning, or adoption of better health practices is more strategic than one collecting revenues or keeping civil peace; or that an organization set up to identify, develop, and disseminate new products, processes, and practices in an industry is more strategic than most firms in that industry; or that voluntary organizations seeking to arouse the awareness of the exploited and mobilize them for collective amelioration and development are more strategic than voluntary organizations that promote only the interests of privileged castes or communities; or that organizations producing the means of further production, such as machinery, are more strategic than organizations producing cosmetics; and so on.

This is not to say that nonstrategic organizations are unimportant—according to some criteria, they may well be even more important. The army, the tax department, and the corporation marketing cigarettes and contributing billions in taxes to government coffers are obviously important. However, their importance vis-à-vis the developmental and transformational goals of a society may be less, or less direct, than that of research laboratories, institutes for training technologists, professional managers, and developmental administrators, social development program organizations, and public enterprises producing equipment for the chemical, fertilizer, engineering, and metal industries.

A typology of strategic organizations

There may be at least three different classes of strategic organizations. The apex developmental organizations of a society or a sector may form one class. The national planning commission and the cabinet are socially apex strategic organizations; the national chamber of commerce and industry, the apex industrial term finance bank, the apex energy development authority, the various ministries of the government, apex cooperative societies,

industry associations, etc., are sectorally apex strategic organizations. In developing societies, these are generally large, government-owned or -financed organizations with considerable social or sectoral clout and public visibility and accountability.

A second class of strategic organizations consists of institutions, enterprises, and development programs that are not apex, but have formal developmental or spearheading missions. Various public enterprises (and also some private enterprises) set up to replace imported by domestically produced goods, pioneer new products, technologies, or industries, develop export markets, provide finance for new ventures or expansion of old ventures, etc., fall into this class, as do educational institutions for training scientists, technologists, and managers or initiating research and development activities in crucial sectors such as defense, energy, industry, and agriculture. Various development programs, e.g., those for integrated rural development, are also members of this class. These strategic organizations are often large, but not necessarily dominant in their sectors; and they tend to play spearheading or pioneering rather than directive roles in these sectors. They also tend to be government owned or funded, though often privately funded as well; and their public visibility or accountability, though considerable, is generally not as great as that of the apex strategic organizations.

Another class consists of human growth organizations that emerge from the initiative of concerned individuals and groups. By and large they tend to be voluntary organizations, cooperative societies, or private corporate bodies. These are missionary organizations, often quite small, dedicated to consciousness raising, social change, human growth, or human welfare³ and operating as change agents in the wrinkles of the social fabric [33. Pp. 327–42]. Private corporations with a social conscience can also be included in this class, especially the foundations or departments they set up for social development. Seldom government-owned, these change-agent human-growth organizations

are, however, commonly dependent on government funding.

Criteria for evaluating strategic organizations

Strategic organizations cannot be evaluated on the basis of just the more common criteria of organizational effectiveness, namely, financial performance, growth, staff well-being, system viability and adaptability, or good corporate citizenship [14,15,17]. They need to be evaluated also—perhaps primarily—according to a new class of criteria pertaining to their socioeconomic developmental impact [19]. The latter may be measured in terms of the extent to which they have pioneered or introduced new (but appropriate) products and technologies (of production as well as management); strengthened (not merely exploited profitably) underdeveloped client systems; created significant positive externalities; collaborated with other organizations in furthering social priorities; promoted social change and awareness about alternative, more autonomous, and science-based life-styles; inculcated a culture of innovation, achievement, social concern, meritocracy, and participative decision-making; etc.

Not every strategic organization should be evaluated according to all these criteria: as a reinforcement mechanism, evaluation should be tilted in favor of the appropriate development-related criteria.

Strategic individuals and teams

Just as there are strategic and nonstrategic organizations, there are strategic and nonstrategic organizational members and groups. Individuals and groups within strategic organizations that have the greatest potential for achieving the developmental, strategic objectives of those organizations may be considered, respectively, strategic individuals and strategic groups. Thus, stra-

tegic individuals may consist of an assortment of owners, managers, technocrats, field workers, client representatives, and union leaders; and strategic groups may consist of such diverse teams as the top management team, the corporate planning group, the research and development group, the human resource development group, the market research group, the spearhead team for an area, and so forth.

The thesis of this paper is that OB can best contribute to socio-economic development of the world's poorer societies by greater concentration on their strategic organizations and, within those strategic organizations, on strategic individuals and groups. Making this sort of an impact through OB implies a program of research on the structure, functioning, adaptation, boundary spanning, effectiveness, and revitalization of strategic organizations; on the leadership, communication, innovation, and institution-building processes within these organizations; on the values, motivations, attitudes, skills, and competency of strategic individuals and teams; and on the interrelations of these variables [34]. It implies greater emphasis on OB as a tool of social transformation, and that OB scholars and practitioners must get busy developing, testing, and deploying the technologies of transformation.

The following sections probe the nature of the strategic organizations of developing societies and explore briefly key OB-related issues in their design and functioning to identify some high-potential research areas.

The nature of strategic organizations in developing societies

A better understanding of the nature of strategic organizations in developing societies may clarify how OB could be pressed into their service. Most strategic organizations in the developing world are likely to share three characteristics: (1) resource de-

pendency on the government, (2) a transformational or developmental role, and (3) unfamiliar tasks.

Resource dependency

In poor societies, all three types of strategic organizations—apex, spearhead, and change agent—tend to be highly dependent on the government for resources. The implication of this resource dependency [35] is extensive government control, that is, political and bureaucratic control over strategic organizations. In turn, these have further implications: the appointments and tenures of the top executives of the larger strategic organizations are often politically mandated, and there is nearly irresistible pressure on strategic organizations to adopt the bureaucratic structures and procedures of the government [25]. The usually large size of the apex and spearhead strategic organizations provides further impetus to bureaucratization [36]. Thus, strategic organizations, especially the apex and spearhead ones, are prone to the well-known dysfunctions of the bureaucratic organization, e.g., rigidity, suboptimization, and interfunctional conflicts, close supervision and staff alienation, and the emergence of a conformist, bureaucratic staff personality [37,38].

On the plus side, being strategic, and therefore enjoying high social priority and legitimacy, also implies a large capacity in the apex and spearhead strategic organizations to raise resources and, therefore, a large loss-bearing capacity [39]. This resource abundance in a scarcity-ridden poor society and this large loss-bearing capacity make it possible for these strategic organizations to be venturesome.

Developmental role and unfamiliar, nonroutine tasks

Although the larger strategic organizations tend to become bur-

eaucratized and to suffer from the dysfunctions of bureaucracy, they must, paradoxically, operate in entrepreneurial [40–43] and organic [44] modes in order to fulfill their developmental missions and to cope with unfamiliar, nonroutine tasks. These strategic organizations, given their developmental missions, programs, products, technologies, and processes, must innovate; they must make bold moves; they must take calculated risks; they must be impelled by a social vision rather than by just mundane considerations; they must operate flexibly in an unfamiliar terrain; they must operate as “open” and participative systems; they must win over their often conservative, traditional, poorly educated, and ignorant clients by persuasion and participative methods; they must adapt to local situations and resist excessive standardization; and they must instill in their rank and file the kind of work, cooperation, and innovation ethic so vital to accomplishment of their mission.

To summarize: Strategic organizations in developing societies usually have access to large governmental and government-controlled resources. Their missions and their loss-bearing capacity enable them to make entrepreneurial moves. But the larger ones are frequently hobbled by bureaucratic structures and dysfunctional practices generated by size and resource dependency on the government. They are also often afflicted by weak organizational work cultures and resistance from conservative beneficiaries.

This combination of operating characteristics bodes ill for the health and social effectiveness of strategic organizations. Indeed, existing research indicates widespread sickness among developmental bureaucracies [25,26], public enterprises of the Third World,⁴ and developmental programs [4]. Case studies of successful Third World development programs [45] and the turnaround of chronically sick public enterprises [46. Ch. 3], however, suggest that effective management of strategic organizations may be daunting, but not impossible. At the heart of their effective management may lie issues of motivation, cohesion, and

change; growth and boundary management; and culture building. These, of course, are also the core of OB.

OB issues in strategic organizations

Strategic organizations should become a major arena of OB research and effectiveness technology. I briefly examine below several fairly well-worked OB issues for their research implications for strategic organizations in developing societies. These issues are: motivation and control; coordination, collaboration, and conflict resolution; boundary management; management of growth; institution building; innovation and change; and revitalization of sick organizations.

Motivation and control in strategic organizations

Motivation of organizational members is one of the more extensively researched areas in OB [47,48]. People join organizations to satisfy their needs. The organization employs people to achieve its goals. It does so through structures, procedures, and systems that often frustrate human needs by making work monotonous or meaningless. So long as the psychic and monetary inducements offered by the organization balance the psychic and monetary contributions made by the staff, so goes Western theory, there is motivation to remain with the organization; and so long as the employee expects that the organization will meet his or her needs if he or she meets the organization's demands, he or she will be motivated to contribute to the organization [37]. Western motivational models are based on the concept of a hierarchy of needs [49], a dynamic aspiration level as an influence on the strength of motivation [50], expectations [51], early socialization into certain enduring motives such as achievement, power, and affiliation [11], and enduring (intrinsic) and

transient (extrinsic) motivation [52], among other factors.

Apex and spearhead strategic organizations, because of their governmental links, tend to have a restricted capacity to offer attractive hiring terms, to fire staff at will, or to remunerate staff handsomely for outstanding performance. Compared with multi-nationals or large professionally managed private enterprises, their capacity to provide attractive, extrinsic motivators is often limited [53]. The change-agent strategic organizations are often too small to pay well. Thus, strategic organizations generally are unable to pay top salaries and perquisites. But their mission and social relevance and their pioneering, innovative, and developmental activities can provide powerful spurs for the idealistic and the enterprising.

Generally speaking, therefore, strategic organizations may have few charms for the money-minded and ample attractions for those with a great need for socially relevant achievement. Strategic organizations that stress opportunities for challenging work, for learning on the job, for socially relevant work, etc., are likely to be able to attract, retain, and energize staff; those that fail to do so may be blighted by an alienated or apathetic staff, high absenteeism, etc. Further research on work dedication,⁵ work commitment [54], achievement need [11], the pioneering-innovating motive [55], extension motivation [56], and the social-achievement motive [57] in Third World settings may help the strategic organizations of developing societies to recruit and promote the right kinds of staff.

Organizations seek to control their members' performance in various ways [58,59]. Performance control in bureaucratic organizations tends to be effected mainly through hierarchical supervision, budgets and quantitative targets, and emphasis on following laid-down procedures [22,25,26,38]. The apex and spearhead strategic organizations, too, therefore tend to rely heavily on these control mechanisms. But overemphasis on these mechanisms may lead to staff alienation and to such distortions as short-

term targetry, neglect of quality, and neglect of hard-to-quantify developmental objectives.

However, important additional means of control are available to strategic organizations. The first is control through pre-entry socialization [60,61], which is commonplace among professionals, and possible in a strategic organization because of its need for professional expertise. The second is control through careful selection of staff with a strong identification with the missions of the organization,⁶ also available to the strategic organization because of its missionary goals. The third is peer-group control [62,63], also available to the strategic organization because developmental tasks are often best accomplished through work teams. Thus, the distortions wrought by hierarchical, budgetary, and procedural control can be contained by the strategic organization emphasizing self, peer, and ideological control. More research on strategic organizations that have successfully harnessed these latter forms of control should yield insights into how to blend them with bureaucratic controls.

Some hypotheses are offered to stimulate research on strategic organizations:

H1. The greater the emphasis on intrinsic motivators, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H2. The greater the use of socialization-based, peer-group, and ideological control, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

Coordination and collaboration in strategic organizations

The very character of formal organizations—vertical differentiation due to a hierarchy of authority and horizontal differentiation through extensive functional specialization, role specialization, and division of labor—predisposes organizations to coordination

difficulties. Western research has uncovered a variety of structural and behavioral mechanisms of coordination, conflict resolution, and collaboration [64]. Structural mechanisms include the hierarchy of authority, division or profit center concept, standardized operating procedures governing relations among potentially conflicting work groups, advance joint planning of operations to anticipate and rectify potential areas of conflict, profit-sharing systems, and others. Behavioral mechanisms include participatory decision-making for reaching consensus, training in interpersonal competence and team building, accentuation of superordinate goals, confrontation meetings to articulate and iron out differences, and organizational socialization and identification creation, among others [65–67].

The apex and spearhead strategic organizations tend to be large and to have diverse goals, and therefore to have relatively high levels of functional and role specializations. This may impede interrole and interfunctional coordination. On the other hand, strategic organizations tend to have missionary goals, and these superordinate goals can engender identification with the organization and promote cohesion within the staff. Continuing emphasis by management on the organization's strategic missions and on communication to the staff of performance on mission-related objectives should offset conflicts engendered by specialization [68]. In addition, adroit institution-building can create a distinctive organizational "clan" culture [69] that tends to contain interrole and interpersonal conflicts.

Apex and spearhead strategic organizations in developing societies often face a couple of distinctive coordination-related problems. As strategic, government-funded organizations, they find it difficult to practice nepotism. Norms of qualifications-based hiring tend to imply a culturally polyglot organizational membership. In these islands of cultural "cosmopolitanism," work relationships and kinship-based relationships often get out of step.⁷

A second problem area is the generation gap from which some

of these strategic organizations in developing countries suffer. This generation gap arises because, in many developing countries, the strategic organizations set up during the initial period of planned development are staffed at the top by the available senior bureaucrats or by generalists with little technical training, and at lower rungs, by young technocrats and, later, by professionally trained managers. The work identities of the senior managers may differ sharply from those of the junior managers [70]: the former may be more traditional and seek obedience and possibly be more intuitive as decision makers, while the latter may seek change, innovation, growth, participation, and professional ways of decision making.

More research on how apex and spearhead strategic organizations have melded polyglot personnel and how they have bridged the generation gap could lead to more effective strategies of organizational integration.

A hypothesis is:

H3. The greater the emphasis on developmental missions in socializing organizational members, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

Boundary management

Operating as “open systems,” organizations must create structures and processes for obtaining the needed inputs and for marketing their outputs [71,72]. In addition, they must establish their institutional legitimacy with the outside world [29]. For controlled organizations it may be especially important to manage their interface with their controllers [73]. Thus, the management of the various boundaries of the organization is an important element of organization design.

For strategic organizations in developing societies, several interfaces with the environment are critical. The first is the inter-

face with the control environment, usually the government and its agencies and institutions [74]; the second, the interface with the intended beneficiaries of the strategic organization, its client system [18]; the third, the interface with the suppliers of technology or know-how⁸; and the fourth, the interface with the network of organizations useful for accomplishing the missions of the strategic organization [45,75].

There are two aspects of the boundary management vis-à-vis the control environment: the management by the control environment of the interface with the strategic organization, and the management by the strategic organization of its interface with the control environment. As progenitor and main purveyor of resources, the control environment has a legitimate interest in mission performance by the strategic organization. This generally translates into the strategic organization's periodically reporting on performance, appointment by the control environment of the top executives and board members of the strategic organization, and other procedures. Additional useful mechanisms available to the control environment include: periodic review meetings with the top management of the strategic organization, some sort of performance-related contracting between the control environment and the strategic organization [76], participative fixation of the goals of the strategic organization that takes realistic note of its situation, considerable operating autonomy for the strategic organization, great care by the control environment in picking the right kind of dedicated professionals for top posts in the strategic organization, and a simultaneously nurturant (in crises), but demanding (in normal circumstances) treatment of the strategic organization [74].

The strategic organization also needs to know how to deal effectively with the control environment [74]. It need not be obsequious, but it pays to cultivate powerful elements in the control environment and create a support network in it. It also pays to inform the control environment early about impending

difficulties or crises and about the traits of the strategic organization or of its operating environment that require special consideration.

Another aspect of boundary management that needs special study is management of the interface with client systems. Many strategic organizations are set up to work with and develop tradition-ridden, apathetic client systems—the Integrated Rural Development Programme is a ready Indian example of such an organization. Too often, however, clients are seen as objects for head counts, so that physical or financial targets may be met, but the essentially human, change and development targets are not considered [77]. It may be useful to co-opt representatives of clients into the strategic organization's decision-making processes [78]. An even more radical possibility may be to set up special organizations whose business it is to organize fragmented and apathetic clients into making demands on the strategic organization.

Thus, in developing societies, a prerequisite for developing the client system may be to conscientize it and make it more cohesive and vociferous [7,79]. Such an investment may not only pressure the strategic organization into providing better services but also may make it more dynamic, progressive, and participative. This external pressure may be a good substitute for the common lack of competitive pressure on the strategic organization. Moreover, if there is competition, a strong client system would tend to induce greater competition, and thus improve both the performance and the management of the strategic organization [80].

Know-how and technology are highly valued resources of many "high tech" strategic organizations in developing societies. These are usually obtained from developed countries. Technology acquisition is a complex process, with the strategic organization, the host government, the supplier's government, and the supplier often being involved in protracted and fluid interactions.⁹

A significant boundary-management problem for the strategic organization is to familiarize itself with the global technology market. A useful technology-choosing heuristic in the early phase of the organization may be to “satisfice”: confine choice to “reputed” suppliers in “friendly” countries; formulate some broad cost and performance criteria; and choose the first supplier who meets those criteria. Further, as experience and skills accumulate, the technology-acquisition decision can be delegated to specialists, comprehensive criteria can be formulated, and an attempt can be made to optimize possibilities of meeting these criteria through global, systematic, technology shopping.¹⁰

Finally, the strategic organization, though often a monopoly, may be just one element in a multitude of organizations that must collaborate for optimal mission accomplishment. Consider the ambitious Integrated Rural Development Programme of India. Unless the program’s organization elicits the cooperation of the nationalized banks, the local governmental administrative organizations, the local self-government organizations, and so forth, there will be minimal impact in the target area on the target population. Thus, the strategic organization must be competent at networking vis-à-vis the other organizations on which it is dependent for mission accomplishment but over which it often has no formal authority at all [45]. It must be able to play a change-agent role in an interorganizational network through appropriate environmental sensing, opportunity spotting, achievement drive, creativity, resourcefulness, collaboration, horse trading, planning, etc.

To summarize: Some very significant areas of OB research on strategic organizations in developing societies pertain to effective management of the interface with the control environment, with the development-oriented interface with the client system, with foreign purveyors of technology, and with interorganizational networks critical for mission accomplishment.

Some hypotheses are offered:

H4. The more nurturant the control environment in adverse circumstances and the more demanding it is in normal circum-

stances, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H5. The more the strategic organization cultivates the support of the control environment, the greater will be its mission accomplishment.

H6. The fuller the representation of the intended beneficiaries in the decision process of the strategic organization, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H7. The greater the familiarity with the technology market, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H8. The greater the mobilization of organizations critical for mission accomplishment into a functioning network, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

Management of growth

The management of growth has become a significant topic in both business policy and organization theory. Western work has explored strategies of diversification and their structural consequences [81,82], phases of growth and their organizational implications [83,84], entrepreneurial strategies [85], and modes of strategy making [86].

There are some distinctive features in the growth management of strategic organizations in developing societies. First of all, the goals of growth differ. Shareholders' wealth, size, or profit maximization (subject to constraints) may be the principal goals of Western corporate growth management; maximization of positive externalities and development of targeted socioeconomic sectors (subject to viability constraints) are the usual principal goals of strategic organizations in developing societies. Often, therefore, strategic organizations enter where

corporate angels may fear to tread.

Second, the charters of apex and spearhead strategic organizations tend to be restricted, so opportunistic conglomerate diversification is less feasible for strategic organizations [87]. This may be fortunate, because conglomerate diversification has generally been found to lead to poorer performance than related diversification [82,88].

Third, subject as strategic organizations in developing societies are to governmental controls, effective boundary management for growth and diversification vis-à-vis the control environment is extremely important [89]. Establishment of goal congruence with the control environment before embarking on growth plans is an essential step.

Fourth, given government-mandated ceilings on remuneration, strategic organizations in developing societies tend to have little availability of, and access to, top-class growth managers [53]. This, along with being very much in a learning situation vis-à-vis professional management systems and relatively unfamiliar with daunting developmental missions, implies great emphasis on a rapid and effective organizational learning strategy. Hence, an effective learning strategy [45,89] may include: learning through pilot projects, often under very difficult operating conditions; starting in a modest way with a single goal rather than in a big way with too many goals; “sticking to the knitting” [90] until management capabilities are built up; phasing expansions; and investing in good performance feedback systems.

Fifth, the developmental thrust and client heterogeneity of strategic organizations in developing societies imply that the impulse to expand by replicating programs or products must be kept in check. Growth implementation needs to be decentralized to tap local opportunities creatively.

Finally, limited managerial and other resources imply a strategy as much of penetration as of withdrawal from areas in which the developmental missions have been achieved. The strategy involves withdrawing not just from “loser” activities but also

from “winner” activities that some other organization(s) can now handle reasonably well.

Effective corporate growth management of the Western variety may have only limited relevance for growth management by strategic organizations. Research on how effective strategic organizations manage growth, especially their learning strategies, and how they disengage from a sector once their missions are accomplished, should be rather useful.

Some hypotheses are:

H9. The more explicitly designed a learning strategy as a component of the growth strategy is, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H10. The greater the parity of the control environment and the organization in evolving a growth strategy, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H11. The more decentralized and situation tailored the implementation of the broad growth strategy, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

H12. The readier the organization is to withdraw from activities or arenas where substantial mission accomplishment has taken place, the greater will be the overall mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

Institution building in strategic organizations

Institution building is the gradual transformation of the formal organization, with its mundane concerns, into a distinctive, well-accepted, social institution that stands for some core values [91–93]. A corporation, for example, becomes an institution when, beyond its customary profit or growth goals, it internalizes values such as being a path breaker, dedication to national priori-

ties, the growth of its human resources, or trusteeship, etc. These values are held not just by the top management: they are shared by the rank and file, and concretely express themselves in the organization's policies and internal and external transactions.

Criteria for assessing the effectiveness of institution building may be diverse; some that have been suggested are capability development, innovative thrust, and domain penetration [94]. A number of processes and choices that contribute to institution building have been identified. These include birth processes such as idea origination and nurturance and choice of institutional form; developmental processes, such as culture creation through initial recruitment, decision making, leadership, structuring, boundary management, etc.; renewal processes encompassing leadership changes, mission redefinition, etc.; and institutionalization processes such as relevance building and environmental impact [92].

Institution building is of obvious importance to the developing world, for formal, strategic organizations are the instruments of the developing world not only for achieving specific developmental missions but also for charging traditional and conservative societies with the new values of innovation and science-based modernization, democratic functioning, primacy of human growth, professionalism, and the growth and development of underdeveloped client systems.

Strategic organizations in a developing society are at an advantage vis-à-vis institution building, for compared with a run-of-the-mill corporation or a government bureau, they start with transformational missions. The initial choices, however, are important. If people with a bureaucratic or political orientation are put in charge of the fledgling strategic organization, the chances are that the organization will get "set" as a bureaucracy or as a "spoils system." If, however, people with a sense of mission, a team-building, participative, decision-making orientation, concern for quality, and strong networking capabilities are put in

charge, it is likely that they will recruit like-minded persons, and institution-building values will be established [95].

More often than not, the resource dependence of the strategic organization on the government takes its toll, and the strategic organization degenerates into a sick organization, heavily bureaucratized and politicized. In terms of life cycles [84], the strategic organization may have two opposite ones: an organic youth with a bureaucratic or political head, goal displacement [96], the institutionalization of bureaucratic values or the values of the "spoils system," decay and degeneration into sickness versus an organic youth with a dedicated, participative, well-connected professional as head, capability development, team building, goal elaboration, innovative thrust, and market or domain penetration and impact.

Research on alternative institution-building life cycles should provide many insights into effective transformation of blueprints and bureaucracies into living bridges to social growth.

A hypothesis is:

H13. The more mission-congruent the initial choices of chief executive and top managers, and the greater their freedom to recruit personnel and to develop policies, operational goals, activities, and structures, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization.

Innovation and change in strategic organizations

Large and bureaucratic though the strategic organization may often be, its business is pioneering, innovation, and change, culminating in socioeconomic development. As perceptive observers of bureaucratic organizations have noted, their bureaucratization impedes introduction of innovations; but once the initial resistance is overcome, the pressure for standardization

can expedite organizationwide adoption of the innovation or change [97,98]. The trick, therefore, is to create a precedent. Thus, attempts to create innovative precedents in marginal parts of the bureaucratized strategic organization or in its marginal activities should facilitate the diffusion of the innovation within the rest of the organization. Decentralization and local-action research should therefore be useful [7].

The organizational leadership may play a critical role; whether it is entrepreneurial and development-oriented or conservative and bureaucratic should make a great difference in the strategic organization's innovativeness [43,85,90,99]. Preference for novel outputs, creativity, experimentation, dynamic young managers, and, simultaneously, for discipline and efficiency may be the strategic policy choices needed to generate a powerful innovation impulse in the organization [99]. A relatively flat structure, the creation of small work groups, and a reasonably effective formal and informal information, control, and planning system may be the structural devices necessary for innovations to take place [85,100,101]. Certain mechanisms can speed up organizational learning in new ventures, such as pilot projects and phased expansions, parallel efforts and "shoot-outs" [101].

Like other large, bureaucratic organizations, strategic organizations tend to accumulate once useful, but currently obsolete practices, policies, and structures. A major opportunity for innovation may be for management to ask periodically: "If the organization were to start all over again, which of its products, technologies, goals, strategies, policies, structures, and practices that it now has would it acquire?" [85]. Such a question opens up vast opportunities for "spring cleaning" and for replacing the obsolete with the currently and futuristically useful.

Periodic informal meetings between the top-level managers and junior, younger managers may be productive. At such meetings the latter may be encouraged to share their aspirations

and ideas for the organization, and the top-level managers may provide briefing on the organization's missions, goals, opportunities, threats, and constraints. Such meetings would help to institutionalize a culture of innovation. The diffusion of innovations within a strategic organization (or a group of similar strategic organizations) can be expedited if details of innovations, both successes and failures, are quickly circulated throughout the organization (or group of organizations) [85].

There may be much potential for innovations at middle-management levels in strategic organizations because these levels are commonly staffed by relatively young technocrats and professional managers eager for change. But the adoption of innovations at lower levels may be a difficult process in strategic organizations because it requires considerable coalition-building activity that cuts across functional and role specialization barriers. Innovation agency may require a variety of skills relatively scarce even in professional managers—an ability, for example, to diagnose innovation opportunities, generate creative and relevant ideas, market ideas to colleagues and superiors, understand and manage the politics of innovation, and build a team for implementing the innovation [102].

Some important research areas vis-à-vis innovation and change in strategic organizations are how centralization and decentralization affect the adoption of what kinds of innovations, the role of top-management ideology, “spring cleaning” as a spur to innovation, vertical two-way communications and innovation, strategic policy choices and innovation, and effective change agency at middle-management levels.

Some hypotheses are:

H14. In a change-resisting, bureaucratic strategic organization, the more local the innovations, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization through innovative means.

H15. The more entrepreneurial, organic, participative, and professional the top management, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization through pioneering and innovative actions.

H16. The more decentralized the organization and the more it recruits or trains change agents at middle levels of management, the greater will be the mission accomplishment by the strategic organization through innovative means.

Revitalization of sick strategic organizations

Organizational sickness may have become a global phenomenon. Organizations, even in the developed West—despite easy access to high-quality technocrats and managerial personnel—fall victim to too fast a change, too much complexity, too much competition, or too many restrictions [103,104]. Such sickness seems to be rampant in the developing world. In India alone, over 100,000 manufacturing units (mostly small-scale units) are sick; a significant percentage of its public enterprises operates at a loss; and sickness in its large, quasi-governmental institutions and governmental departments seems rampant [105]. Fortunately, turnaround research, both in the West and in the Third World, especially in India, has led to the identification of useful models of effective turnaround management [106].

Because of large size, complex, unfamiliar, long-term missions, and a strong interface with the government, strategic organizations are quite prone to organizational sickness, expressed as low morale, infighting, a poor public image, sacrifice of quality for the sake of targetry, and mission failure. Given the often fuzzy goals of strategic organizations, recognition of sickness itself may take a long time [107]. If a spoils system has become installed, the beneficiaries in the political system and in the organi-

zation may resist curative actions. Therefore, even if there is recognition of sickness, an effective consensus to do anything may take long to emerge. These delays may, of course, aggravate the sickness.

It may not be easy to find the right person to revive a sick strategic organization, partly because of the high risk of failure, but partly also because the kind of manager needed to revitalize a sick organization may be very different from the run-of-the-mill professional manager [103]. The turnaround manager needs to be something of an entrepreneur who can quickly see, and seize, opportunities in a murky situation; something of a team builder who, through participative decision-making, can put together a team of dedicated managers for operating the turnaround; something of an expert negotiator who can negotiate concessions and support from the organization's various stakeholders for speeding turnaround; something of a professional manager who can plug the biggest loopholes in the operating management systems; something of a creative learner who comes into an unfamiliar organizational system, learns the ropes fast, and puts together a custom-tailored turnaround strategy; and something of an institution builder who gives a great deal of importance to the values he or she prizes and disseminates them by setting a personal example. The right sort of top-management team, instead of an individual, may find it easier to turn a sick strategic organization around [108,109]. It may make sense for developing countries to train a cadre of turnaround managers.

A number of research questions come to mind. Why is it that a disproportionately large number of strategic organizations do not seem to have an internal capability to prevent sickness or cure themselves and must pathetically wait for outsiders to set them right [104,105,110]? What could be the sizing-up strategies of strangers who come in as rescuers? What initial actions of rescuers could unfreeze a sick organization? What actions would ensure a directional change? What actions could consolidate a turn-

around? How can a society provide its strategic organizations with the right kinds of turnaround managers?

Some hypotheses are:

H17. The quicker the detection of sickness by the control environment, the faster will be the turnaround of the strategic organization.

H18. Given predominantly internal causes of sickness, the faster the replacement of the top management by an outsider—individual or team—with qualities of dynamism and professionalism, the faster will be the turnaround of the strategic organization.

H19. Given predominantly internal causes of sickness, the greater the concentration of initial effort in quick payoff credibility-building efforts, mobilization of the staff, and the co-option of the stakeholders in the turnaround, the faster will be the turnaround of the strategic organization.

Concluding comments

OB for social development is an exciting and overdue paradigm shift from organizational narcissism. The primary instrumentality of this paradigm shift is research focus on the strategic organizations of the developing world, especially on motivation and control, coordination, boundary spanning, innovation and change, growth management, institution building, and sickness and revitalization. Such a paradigm shift not only would make OB immeasurably more relevant to over two-thirds of the globe's population but should bring in its train exciting new concepts, approaches, and techniques that may revolutionize OB.

Fortunately, the opportunities for studying strategic organizations in Third World countries may be sizable. The strategic organization tends to be rife with "people" problems, thanks to

Table 2

Some OB Issues and Research Opportunities Vis-à-vis Strategic Organizations

OB issues in strategic organizations	Significant opportunities for further OB research
1. Motivation and control in strategic organizations	1. Impediments to offering extrinsic and intrinsic motivators, particularly challenging, socially relevant jobs 2. Research on such other powerful and durable motivators at work as dedication to work and conscientiousness, extension motivation, patriotism, pioneering-innovating motivation, the need to sacrifice for a cause, etc. 3. Research on inspiring, charismatic, missionary-type leadership, found more commonly in military organizations in wartime and among political leaders of revolutionary movements 4. Consequences of using bureaucratic forms of performance control (hierarchy, budgets, rules); potential for using self, peer group, and ideological forms of control
2. Coordination, conflict resolution, and interpersonal collaboration in strategic organizations	1. Effect on coordination and collaboration of "fair," qualifications-based, non-nepotistic hiring practices, "generation gap," etc. 2. Potential for improving coordination and collaboration through greater emphasis on missionary motivation of selected personnel, indoctrination of staff in organizational mission, institution- and team-building processes 3. Need to research the right mix of bureaucracy, behavior, and culture re specific coordination, conflict-resolution, and collaboration-inducing mechanisms
3. Boundary management in strategic organizations	1. Control environment's management of interface with strategic organization 2. Strategic organization's management of interface with control environment, especially networking within the control environment for support to the organization 3. Client development by strategic organizations 4. Technology acquisition management by strategic organizations 5. Networking with other organizations for mission accomplishment

Table 2 (continued)

OB issues in strategic organizations	Significant opportunities for further OB research
4. Growth management in strategic organizations	1. Rapid organizational learning strategies for growth in unfamiliar areas (pilot projects, single goals, phasing, starting small, starting small in the most difficult part of the domain) 2. Organizational strategies for withdrawing from domains in which developmental missions are completed 3. Establishment of criteria of success for mission accomplishment 4. Negotiation of support from control environment for growth goals and initiatives 5. Implications of growth for organizational structure, staff motivation, coordination, etc. 6. Leadership needed at operating levels to manage growth
5. Institution building in strategic organizations	1. The long-term effects of initial policy, structure, and other choices for institution building 2. Socialization processes for institution building 3. Leadership style for institution building 4. How strategic organizations can capitalize on their inherent external legitimacy 5. How core values get introduced and institutionalized in the strategic organization 6. How institutionalized core values affect the strategy, structure, performance pattern, etc., of the strategic organization 7. Alternative institution-building life cycles of strategic organizations 8. Co-option of appropriate social-cultural mechanisms in institution building

Table 2 (continued)

OB issues in strategic organizations	Significant opportunities for further OB research
6. Innovation and change in strategic organizations	9. The use of OD technology for institution building
	1. The role of precedents in the diffusion of innovations within strategic organizations; facilitators of precedent creation
	2. Creation of a culture of innovation in the face of bureaucratic structure; the role of top-management leadership, strategic choices
	3. Organizational structure and control systems that are congruent with emphasis on innovation
	4. Innovation-spurring practices—periodic junking of obsolete practices, periodic informal meetings between top-level and junior managers, circulation within the organization of diagnoses of organization successes as well as failures, local action research, etc.
7. Revitalization of sick strategic organizations	5. Innovation change agency within the strategic organization at operating levels
	1. Proneness of the strategic organization to fall sick (because of large size, bureaucratization due to external dependency, etc.)
	2. Factors that inhibit self-cure by the strategic organization
	3. Internal and external recognition of the sickness of the strategic organization and the development of indicators of organizational sickness
	4. Traits and abilities of effective turnaround managers/teams
	5. Initial actions for "unfreezing" a paralyzed strategic organization, for initiating a change of direction, and for consolidating a revitalization
	6. Mechanisms for preventing recurrence of sickness

its daunting missions, bureaucratic structure, kinship-oriented staff, and conservative clientele. Both the control environment and the strategic organization's management should generally be keen to get whatever help they can from the social scientist in "taming the beast."

Moreover, strategic organizations in a developing society, especially the apex and spearhead ones, are perpetually trying out something or other. One year it is diversification; another year it is computerization; a third year it is structural reorganization; a fourth year it is MBO, or quality circle, or T-group, or stress management, or creativity training, or OD, or something else. The point is that strategic organizations of developing societies offer exceptionally rich sites for natural experiment-type research. In the latter there is experimental manipulation, but the choice of what to manipulate, and how, rests with management, not with the researcher [111]. All the OB researcher has to do is contact the strategic organization intending to undertake an experiment and negotiate "before," "during," and "after" measurements of structure, strategy, style, culture, leadership, values, or whatever else the OB researcher fancies. An extensive natural experiment-based research strategy should provide invaluable data for OB conceptualization and technology. Table 2 summarizes some significant OB research issues pertaining to the strategic organizations of the Third World.

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